

# Empowering Women For Viksit Bharat 2047

Enabling India's Transformation through a Framework of Women-led Development



**I**N 2023, India's G20 presidency marked a pivotal shift in the discourse on gender equality, showcasing a paradigm shift from women's development, where women are viewed as passive recipients of welfare, to women-led development, where they are recognised as active agents of change. This shift aligns with India's vision of the 'Viksit Bharat 2047' mission, which places women at the centre of the development agenda. This initiative is not only a moral imperative but also an economic necessity. As the Indian Prime Minister said during the G20 ministerial conference, "When women prosper, the world prospers, and we must work to remove the barriers that restrict women's access to markets, global value chains, and affordable finance."

India's case for women's participation in the economy is simple. Women constitute about 48.4 per cent of India's total population, while their contribution to the country's GDP is restricted to 17 per cent. A McKinsey (2015) report estimated that bridging the gender gap between men and women in employment could improve India's GDP by \$2.9 trillion by 2025. Additionally, the International Monetary Fund estimated that boosting female labour force participation by 5.8 per cent may boost GDP in emerging economies by 8 per cent after the pandemic. These numbers clearly signal that women are critical economic development and growth architects. India seems to have recognised the truth.

According to the Periodic Labour Force Survey of India (2023-24), the country has witnessed a remark-

able increase in the female labour force participation rate to 41.7 per cent from 23.3 per cent in 2017.

At every stage of a woman's lifecycle, they face barriers, including an unequal burden of unpaid care work. Our study, *A Framework for Women-Led Development – India's Initiative for Global Transformation*, was undertaken to analyse this subject in greater detail, which highlighted the following issues:

Employment and entrepreneurship emerged as the twin engines that could turbo-charge women-led development. But access to these opportunities is often mediated by invisible hurdles like patriarchal norms, safety concerns, financial illiteracy, etc.

The framework developed in the above-mentioned study recognises inputs such as education, healthcare, and supportive policies. Additionally, a combination of intrinsic factors (e.g., motivation, resilience) and extrinsic factors (e.g., family and community support) was found to create development outcomes at multiple levels — individual, household, community,



**(From left)**  
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and organisational.

In our study, we show that while India has a wide array of programmes and schemes targeting the upliftment of women, they need serious rationalisation. Such programmes are currently 'housed' in different ministries and departments. Bringing them all under one roof, ideally the Women & Child Development Ministry, would be useful to align, integrate, and focus (impact measurement) appropriately.

An important dimension that needs attention is to first clearly understand and then design the required ecosystem that will enable these programmes and schemes to reach the target population, and subsequently, handhold and extend sustained support to benefit from them. Breaking silos and strengthening the convergence of government schemes will go a long way in realising the desired objectives.

It is now apparent that women-

led development will require not just fresh policy formulation but robust implementation and sincere impact measurement. Investments must continue to target and alleviate persistent gender gaps in education, digital access, and skill development. Equally critical is the issue of recognising and attaching an economic value to unpaid work and the caregiving that women are unequally burdened with. This unpaid care work supports entire economic operations but is not recognised under GDP calculations. Public investments in childcare, elder care, and mandatory social security benefits for women in employment would go a long way in encouraging women to realise their true potential.

India is home to 90 lakh women-led Self-Help Groups (SHGs), engaging over 10 crore women. In the Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises (MSME) sector, 20.5 per cent of registered businesses are now owned by women. However, they contribute less than 19 per cent to employment, revealing a significant productivity and scale gap. Handholding support to bridge these gaps will galvanise women-led

enterprises to drive broader developmental outcomes.

Finally, women's leadership must be fostered at all levels.

Entrepreneurship is known to nurture leadership, and in India, women's leadership at the grassroots level is already becoming robust and driving local change. Women's roles as sarpanches, self-help group leaders, and community health workers are visible, and enhancing their capacity through training, mentorship, and institutional support is essential to transform their

leadership at the national level. Actively promoting women's leadership in governance and enterprise levels of organisations and institutions is critical.

After all, women-led development is not just about equity, it is a blueprint for sustainable and inclusive national growth. 



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